Words

(from the Cancer Monologue Project)

By Christine Barber

INTRODUCTION

***Biopsy**-A procedure where a piece of tissue is taken from a person's body and examined to determine if a person has cancer and, if so, what type it is.*

***Prognosis**-A prediction of what might*

***Radiation Therapy**-X-ray treatment that damages or kills cells.*

***Remission**-The disappearance of cancer symptoms*

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I'm not a crier, but I cried that day. Wracking, can't-catch-your-breath sobs, as I sat in my car in the hospital parking lot. A woman glanced at me as she walked by, seeing my smeared mascara, blotchy lipstick and cheeks streaked with tears. She probably thought I was sad. The doctor had said the scan "looked good." I

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waited until I was alone in my care to break down in relief. I called everyone on my cell phone, telling them my scan was clean. The thyroid cancer that had spread to my lungs was gone. I cried more. I started my care and headed for the Glorieta Baptist Center. I wanted to walk in the prayer garden, the only green place I could think of in December. I need to be outside, near God

As I drove, I thought of the past year, the surgery, the radiation I had ten months ago. That damn radiation, where I sat for three days in a lead-lined room, my only constant visitor a hospital tech who checked me every few hours with some type of Geiger counter. Most of the room was covered in plastic, like when you visit your paranoid grandmother who Saran-wraps the sofa in case you spill something. The hospital put plastic on the phone, the toilet, the bed to protect them – from me, from my radioactivity. I was a radioactive danger to society. A prisoner in a lead-lined room who must be kept away from all the healthy people. The very nice doctors and very nice nurses who came in stood behind lead-lined screens, staring at me.

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I drank bottle after bottle of Gatorade to coax the radiation out of my body, the sweet taste sticking to the roof of my mouth. I didn't think about the plastic, the Gatorade or the very nice nurses. I just made it all into an amusing story I told the people who called me on the plastic-covered phone. I described with a laugh the weird three-flush toilet ritual I had to perform and the visits from the Geiger-counter man. I didn't tell the callers about what the radiation was doing to me, seeping and creeping into my every cell. I didn't think about what it was doing to my ovaries, my eggs—my eggs that were no contaminated by radiation. I made jokes to my sister on the phone about how my unborn kids would be superheroes, the radiation giving them the ability to bend steel and talk to fish. I didn't tell her about my fears that I would now be childless.

I left the hospital after my three days and tried very hard not to think about that lead-lined room. I thought about work, school, guys, guacamole, anything but cancer. Did I really have cancer? Five months after I left the hospital, I was in Target, the bright,

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fluorescent lights giving everything a weird, radioactive glow. How the meaning of that word has changed for me. I don't even remember what I was shopping for, probably something innocuous like cotton balls, toothpaste or a lava lamp. Everyone at work had been telling me how "fabulous" I looked, but I always wondered if they were lying as they tried not to stare at the neon pink surgical scar across my neck. The other Target shoppers didn't even glance at my scar. I convinced myself that meant it wasn't noticeable, as I grabbed my cotton balls or lava lamp and headed to the checkout line. I plunked my purchases on the counter, not paying much attention to what I was doing, my mind, my eyes, my everything, on something else.

And then I heard, "Hey, it's the Scar Lady."

I looked up. I'd seen this cashier before. His face was pink with acne. He had piggy little eyes of a piggy little, nondescript color. He was tall and bony, not yet grown into his body.

For one tiny second that will stretch out for the rest of my life, I hated that stupid, idiotic sixteen-

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year-old boy. A boy who was only trying to be friendly in his awkward teenage way. I hated him because he made me remember that I'd had cancer. I hated him because he told the truth when no one else would. He saw my scar and, for once, unlike every single person before him, he didn't say I looked "fabulous." He saw my scar for what it was: horrible. He told it like it was. I mumbled "hello" to the boy and left as quickly as I could, not wanting him to see the anger in my eyes.

Five months later the doctor said my cancer was gone and that silly boy became nothing more than a funny story for me to tell at dinner parties.

That December day as I pulled into the prayer garden, I thought about making myself a bumper sticker that read "Make Way for the Scar Lady." I laughed at my own joke as I got out of the car, beaming, my face still wet with tears. I prayed and thanked God as I walked. I even got down on my knees in the icy mud. Hallelujah and all that. I found a quiet bench next to an unbelievably tall ponderosa pine and sat down to write in my journal. I wrote, "Today I walk in the garden of

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God," and thought "What a nice thing to put on a tombstone." My tombstone. Someday, fifty years from now. In the faraway future when I died of old age or an accident involving a llama and a Go-Kart, not cancer. I was joyous. I had always heard that word used in church songs and never understood it. That was my most joyous day. Isn't that pathetic? My most joyous day involved cancer. No my graduation from college, not getting the big job. But a deadly illness.

How funny that day seems now. Not "ha, ha" funny, but horrible funny.

Almost a year after that day, I went to the doctor's office for a checkup. I sat on the examination table, my feet not reaching the ground, kicking my legs like some elementary school kid sent to the principal's office. I was there for a checkup. A simple checkup. Nothing more. Just a checkup like I had several times since finding out my cancer was gone.

The office was cold, but it always was. The nurse was looking at my chart, not at me. Always at my chart with all those bright green Post-it notes on the front

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that I couldn't read from a distance no matter how much I scrunched up my eyes. The nurse's brow was furrowed. Her red hair was wispy at the ends where it was dried from too much hair dye. I was bored. As always when I'm bored, I made a joke. I don't remember exactly what I said. Something about being in remission. I laughed, but she didn't. She seemed so hesitant, so unsure. She said something about "traces." She said the scan last year, the same scan the doctor said "looked good," showed traces of cancer. I still had cancer. I was confused, too confused to ask questions. Too confused to wonder why the doctor hadn't mentioned that I still had cancer during my last three office visits. Had it just never come up in conversation? The nurse said when the doctor told me the scan "looked good," he meant the cancer hadn't spread, not that it was gone.

I work in words. I know their power. The doctor had said it "looked good," the same as saying "You're cured," right? In journalism we call it paraphrasing a quote. I paraphrased that quote for a full year to my

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family, my friends, myself, telling everyone I was cured. The doctor said so when he saw my scan, didn't he? Or did I just hear what I wanted? Did I just want to forget so badly about lead-lined hospital rooms and awkward cashiers that I turned it around in my head?

I needed facts. I needed this nurse with her bad dye job to tell me facts. I hand on to facts like that pink security blanket I had as a kid, the one I clutched into pieces while warding off the monsters in my closet. But she told me nothing in her sidestepping medical-speak. She just talked about "traces." I used to like that word. It sounds like it could be the name of an upscale apartment complex: "The Traces de Pinon – An exclusive apartment community in the beautiful Sangre de Cristo Mountains."

The nurse was nice and polite, bad hair and all; too polite to comment on how I melted into nothingness in front of her. I still think about the scene in the doctor's office like it was inside a snow globe, and I'm on the outside, shaking up the globe and peering inside at

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the falling snow. It's apart from me, not touching me. In some wonderland far away.

What now? What do I say to you now? I don't know the answer to that. I wish I had some nice, happy ending to give you, complete with a handsome prince and a Disney song. But the truth is I'm still furious and devastated. That about covers it. Not much more to say than that. Too furious and too devastated for words.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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